

The 6:15

THURSDAY · SEPTEMBER 17, 2026

NO. 15

THE BOARD

CALENDAR (NEXT 10 DAYS)

Today 9/17	Aug. housing starts, 8:30a ET (cons. 1.318M SAAR, up from July's 1.239M); Aug. industrial production, 9:15a ET (cons. +0.3% m/m, cap. util. 76.4%) — neither had printed as of this issue's ~6:15a writing time. [Correction] FedEx's actual next report is Oct. 28, not Fri. 9/18 as issue No. 14 carried; Lennar's Wed. 9/16 results not independently verified this run.
Fri 9/18	Bank of Japan decision, Tokyo; presser 3:30p JST = 2:30a ET Fri. Current BOJ rate 0.75%.
Mon 9/22	SpaceX Starship Flight 14, targeted 12:15p UTC / 8:15a ET — first Starship flight with an operational payload (26 Starlink V3 sats), ~10-hr mission, Pacific splashdown, no catch planned.
Thu 9/24	Costco earnings, aft. close, cons. ~\$6.54 EPS / ~\$94.5B rev. (~10% y/y) [aggregator-sourced] . No OPEC+ meeting date confirmed in this window this run.
[NEW, retrospective]	Impulse Space raised a \$308M Series D extension 9/16 (total \$808M); Anew Labs raised \$290M at a \$1.5B valuation, same day [aggregator-sourced] .

METRICS · AS OF ~6:15A ET THU 9/17 UNLESS NOTED

Rates/FX/vol	10Y 5.016-5.02% (highest close since July 2007, crossed 5% for the first time since Nov. 2023), Wed 9/16 close; 2Y 4.39%, 30Y 5.25% (both Tue 9/15) [stale, pre-hike] . DXY 100.07 (12:09a ET Thu, first close above 100 in weeks). VIX 17.20 (Wed close, vs. 15.84 a week ago).
Oil	WTI ~\$102.13 (Thu a.m.), fell below \$103 Wed on reports Aramco can restore ~half the damaged East-West pipeline's capacity within days [see Lead] . Brent:

Wed close \$108.75; Thu a.m. range \$107.19-109.08, last \$107.77.

Equities	Wed 9/16 close (post-FOMC): Dow 51,461.90 (-1.21%); S&P 500 7,551.81 (-0.45%); Nasdaq Comp. 25,978.42 (-0.01%) — all three traded higher intraday before the 2p decision. Thu premarket futures modestly higher (+0.2% to +0.5%).
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Other	Gold ~\$4,310-4,329/oz (~4:23-5:21a ET Thu, +\$47.80 on the day per Kitco). Retail gas \$4.3672/gal natl. avg (AAA, 9/16), up from \$4.3163 (9/14). Nikkei ~64,136 (+0.33%) [level not independently corroborated] ; Hang Seng ~24,713 (-0.63%); Shanghai ~3,876 (-0.41%). Europe (Wed close): FTSE +0.2%; DAX 25,537.75 (+0.53%).
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Crude via ICE Brent/NYMEX WTI front-month indicative (no confirmed settle located pre-press); rates via Fed H.15/aggregators; equities via exchange closes/CNBC.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Transits	IMF PortWatch: 8 transits on 9/13 vs. an 85/day pre-crisis baseline. Kpler 10-day rolling avg.: ~13/day [reference date not pinned down this run] .
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War-risk premia	Lloyd's List-sourced: 1-3% of hull value (from 0.25% pre-crisis) — \$10M-\$14M to insure a voyage, \$1.5M-\$4.5M per transit on a \$150M tanker vs. ~\$375K pre-crisis [underlying article may predate this week] .
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Closures/strikes	No fresh closure-day count, dark-tanker figure, or new strike log independently verified this run; last issue's Day 195/196 split (straits.live vs. globalsecurity.org) not updated rather than guessed forward.
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PortWatch's daily transit count, Kpler's AIS rolling average, and Lloyd's List's hull-value premium estimate measure different things over different windows — never netted or averaged.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Clinched AL top wild card Mon. 9/14 (beat Minnesota, 87-63 at the time); lost 5-4 in extra innings to the Twins Wed. 9/16 [exact post-loss record not reconciled] .
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Knicks	Hart extension unsigned; eligible up to 4-yr/\$132M, reporting still points to a likelier 3-yr/\$54-62M.
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Northwestern	1-0; hosts Colorado (2-0) Sat. 9/19, 7:30p ET, Fox.
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LEAD

A NEW FED CHAIR HIKES, THE 10-YEAR CLEARS 5% — AND A SAUDI PIPELINE, NOT DIPLOMACY, EASES OIL

A new Fed chair delivers the first hike since 2023 and the 10-year clears 5% for the first time since 2007 — but it's a damaged Saudi pipeline, not the collapsed Hormuz diplomacy, that's actually easing oil

Wednesday closed a loop this issue has been tracking since hike odds first started climbing three weeks ago: the FOMC raised its target range 25bp, to 3.75%-4.00%, on a 12-0 vote — the first increase since 2023 — effective Sept. 17. [fact, [federalreserve.gov](https://www.federalreserve.gov)] The committee's statement cited resilient domestic spending, strong productivity growth, robust capital investment, and job gains keeping pace with the workforce, while flagging that "uncertainty remains elevated owing, in part, to geopolitical developments." [fact] It was also a first: this was Kevin Warsh's inaugural meeting running the press conference as Fed chair, not Jerome Powell's. Warsh was confirmed 54-45 in May and sworn in May 22; Powell remains a sitting governor through 2028 but no longer chairs the Committee — a standing fact worth flagging plainly, since this issue has been imprecise about it. [fact]

Warsh's framing in the presser was pointedly narrow: "We cannot affect any individual price," he said, naming oil and groceries specifically, arguing the Fed's job is to stop a relative-price shock from broadening into "second and third order effects" through the rest of the economy. [fact] He said three things had changed since the last meeting, and led with stronger-than-expected economic data — a reference, most plausibly, to Wednesday morning's August retail

sales, which beat sharply: headline +1.2% m/m against an +0.8% consensus, the largest monthly gain in five months, with the control group up 1.4% against a downwardly revised -0.4% in July. [fact] Reporting citing the dot plot has 16 of 18 participants projecting at least one more hike before year-end, with year-end fed-funds projections clustering 4.1%-4.4%. [fact, sourced to CNBC/Raisin coverage of the SEP — recommend a direct SEP-document check before treating as final] Put together: a hawkish committee, under a new chair explicitly trying to draw a line against second-round inflation effects, hiking into data that gave it cover rather than into weakness. [read]

Markets took the hawkishness at face value. All three major averages had traded higher ahead of 2p Wednesday and gave it back on the decision and presser: the Dow fell 1.21% (-631.21pts) to 51,461.90, the S&P 500 lost 0.45% to 7,551.81, and the Nasdaq closed essentially flat, -0.01%, at 25,978.42. [fact] The bond market's reaction was sharper and more durable: the 10-year yield pushed through 5% and closed around 5.02%, its highest level since July 2007 — a level that had held since November 2023 through every prior scare this issue has tracked. [fact] The dollar index cleared 100 for the first time in weeks, trading around 100.07 just after midnight ET, with one technical read flagging the move as overbought (RSI 83.54) and noting a hawkish dot plot has now removed previously priced 2027 rate cuts entirely. [fact, single-source technical read — directional confidence, not the RSI figure specifically]

The part that complicates the simple "hawkish Fed, stronger dollar, weaker risk assets" story is oil, and it's moving for a reason that has nothing to do with Wednesday's decision. This issue's last edition flagged a reported Monday meeting in Salalah, Oman, where GCC

and Iranian diplomats were expected to discuss a temporary Hormuz shipping arrangement; that meeting never happened. Oman's foreign minister announced the day before that it was "postponed... in the interests of consensus," after Saudi Arabia submitted amendments over concerns about the framework's lasting implications for Hormuz, blocking consensus; Iran said it would proceed bilaterally with Oman regardless. [fact, corrects last issue's expectation] So the diplomatic route to easing Gulf oil-supply risk collapsed entirely last weekend — and yet crude has eased anyway, on a different mechanism. Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline, the 1,200km, 4-5mn bbl/day route that lets the kingdom move crude to the Red Sea port of Yanbu without transiting Hormuz, was knocked offline after a drone strike damaged two pumping stations; sources dispute whether the strike originated from Iraq (per initial CNBC reporting) or was a Houthi operation (per subsequent trade-press coverage), and that attribution question is unresolved here. [flag: sourcing conflict on the strike's origin] What moved the market Wednesday was Bloomberg's report that Aramco can restore roughly half the pipeline's capacity within days, with full capability targeted in about six weeks — pushing WTI below \$103 for the first time in several sessions. [fact] The mechanism, then, is a supply-side repair to a Hormuz workaround, not a de-escalation of the underlying Iran conflict, which is worth distinguishing clearly: Hormuz itself remains constrained (see Iran & Hormuz), and this is Saudi Arabia fixing its own bypass, not Tehran opening the strait.

The setup into Friday and next week is genuinely two-sided. A Fed that just hiked, with 16 of 18 participants penciling in more, sits against a 10-year at an 18-year high and a dollar breaking a multi-week range — a combination that tightens financial conditions well

beyond the 25bp move itself. [read] Whether oil keeps easing depends on execution risk in the Aramco repair timeline that a six-week full-restoration target doesn't remove, not on any actual reduction in the number of ships willing to run the strait itself. [read]

POLITICS

The Supreme Court on Sept. 14 blocked the Trump administration's bid to implement new USPS mail-in-ballot rules ahead of the 2026 midterms, denying a request to lift a Boston federal judge's injunction; Justice Kavanaugh wrote the rule might fall within USPS's authority in principle but that states and localities lack time to implement it before the elections. [fact] Trump called the ruling "a big loss for Republicans." [fact] Separately, the House Oversight Committee voted 41-0 on Sept. 16 to recommend contempt against Leon Black for defying Epstein-probe subpoenas — he failed to appear on Sept. 3 and to produce requested NDAs — and the full House adopted the contempt resolution, referring the matter to DOJ for a prosecution decision; Black has separately sued the committee. [NEW] [fact] Neither story moves markets directly, but both narrow the administration's near-term legislative and legal bandwidth heading into a midterm cycle already complicated by war-driven inflation. [read]

ECONOMICS

Wednesday's retail-sales beat is covered in the Lead; the other economic story this week is what the war is costing, quantified. A CBO estimate circulated Sept. 15 attributes more than 40% of Q2 2026 inflation to the Iran war, chiefly via reduced Hormuz and Red Sea shipping volumes, and projects it will add roughly 0.5

percentage points to Q1 2027 inflation on the same channel. [fact, single-sourced to CBO reporting this run] CBO put the direct war cost at roughly \$38 billion through Aug. 1, running \$2-3 billion a month since. [fact] The same reporting cited the 30-year mortgage rate at 7.22% as of Tuesday 9/15, against a sub-6% rate before the war began — a housing-affordability channel that compounds whatever the Fed's own 25bp move does to financing costs. [read] Weekly jobless claims for the week ended Sept. 5 — the most recent confirmed print — came in at 206,000 against a roughly 205,000 estimate, essentially in line and still near this cycle's lows; today's newer weekly claims figure, along with housing starts and industrial production, had not printed as of this issue's writing time (see Board). [fact] Friday's Bank of Japan decision (2:30a ET) is a secondary watch item: the BOJ's own rate sits at 0.75% against a Fed that just moved to 3.75-4.00%, and a widening differential the same week the dollar cleared 100 is the kind of setup that has produced carry-trade unwind volatility before. [read]

BUSINESS

Oracle shares have given back the entirety of their 2025 gains during 2026, trading \$139.00-\$146.50 intraday this week (last \$144.56, market cap \$433B), as investors weigh a \$664B contracted backlog against the capital intensity of the AI buildout funding it; CEO Larry Ellison cancelled a planned \$7.5B stock sale on Sept. 11 amid the decline. [NEW] Analyst consensus remains "Buy" with a 12-month average price target near \$239, implying roughly 70% upside from current levels — a wide gap that reflects how much the stock's recent slide has been sentiment- rather than fundamentals-driven. [fact, read] Adobe reported fiscal Q3 (period ended Aug. 28) revenue of \$6.76B, up 13% y/y and above the \$6.70B consensus, with non-

GAAP EPS of \$6.13 versus \$6.09 expected, and raised full-year guidance to \$26.50B-\$26.60B in revenue; shares still fell roughly 1.9% after-hours on Q4 guidance of \$6.80B-\$6.85B, slightly below the \$6.85B consensus midpoint. [NEW] Adobe also announced a CEO transition: Anil Chakravarthy becomes CEO on Dec. 1, with Shantanu Narayen moving to executive chair. [NEW] [fact] Separately, the 90-day underwriter lockup from SpaceX's June 11 IPO is due to begin expiring in late September, with sequential 7% employee-share tranches unlocking afterward — a float-expansion event worth flagging for anyone positioned in SPCX, though the exact date wasn't independently pinned down this run. [flag: thin-sourced] No other major M&A, regulatory action, or earnings surprise beyond Oracle and Adobe was located this run.

TECHNOLOGY

The more interesting AI-adjacent story this week isn't a model release — none landed in the last 48 hours — but the funding market underneath the frontier labs. Sept. 16 brought a cluster of rounds: Impulse Space's \$308M Series D extension for orbital-transport hardware (total Series D now \$808M), Anew Labs' \$290M inaugural round for Shanghai-based AI drug discovery at a \$1.5B valuation, and smaller extensions at Hang Ten Systems (enterprise AI, \$53M, \$85M total) and CADDi (¥17.7B Series D). [NEW] [flag: aggregator-sourced this run, worth a Crunchbase/TechCrunch cross-check before treating exact figures as final] The pattern — infrastructure and applied-science rounds alongside enterprise-software extensions, rather than another frontier-model lab raise — is a read worth watching if it continues: capital may be rotating toward AI-adjacent hard-tech and vertical applications rather than concentrating further in the foundation-model layer. [read] On the

OpenAI-NYU Navier-Stokes credit dispute flagged in prior issues:
no update since Sept. 12 was located this run; it remains unresolved
between the two accounts. [continuity]

GEOPOLITICS

ISW's Sept. 16 assessment reports Ukrainian forces killed Russian 4th Motorized Rifle Brigade commander Maj. Gen. Anton Grunis in a drone strike in occupied Donetsk City on Sept. 12; Russia launched roughly 80 drones against Ukraine overnight into Sept. 16, and both sides reported localized gains — Ukraine near Lyman and Oleksandrivka, Russia in Lyman and western Zaporizhzhia. [NEW] [fact] Zelensky said Russian drones have targeted his aircraft over Moldova twice in the past two weeks; Lithuania confirmed a Russian Gerbera drone entered its airspace overnight Sept. 14-15. [NEW] [fact] Putin is reportedly framing this month's State Duma elections as a referendum on the war. [fact, single-sourced this run] No new Witkoff-Kushner shuttle-diplomacy development was located since their early-September trip. [continuity]

IRAN & HORMUZ

The pipeline mechanics are in the Lead; the strait itself remains separately constrained. IMF PortWatch and Kpler both show Hormuz transit volume still running at roughly 10-15% of the pre-crisis baseline (see Board), a level essentially unchanged from prior issues despite this week's pipeline and diplomatic news. [fact] The Bab el-Mandeb/Red Sea theater — Houthi control of Mokha port and Perim Island, reported in issue No. 14 — has no new development located since Sept. 12; that situation is carried forward unchanged, not repeated in detail. [continuity] On the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement, flagged in prior issues as a possible escalation mechanism if Saudi Arabia is struck again: this week's East-West pipeline strike is exactly the kind of attack that clause was written to

cover, and no invocation, formal response, or statement from Saudi Arabia, Pakistan, or Turkey was located this run — worth watching directly next issue given the strike actually landed on Saudi infrastructure. [flag: not yet invoked, unconfirmed either way] [read]

SPORTS

Yankees	Clinched AL top wild card Mon. 9/14 (87-63 at the time); lost 5-4 in extra innings to Minnesota Wed. 9/16 at Target Field — current record not reconciled this run.
Knicks	Hart extension unsigned; eligible up to 4-yr/\$132M, likelier landing 3-yr/\$54-62M.
Northwestern	1-0; hosts Colorado (2-0) Sat. 9/19, 7:30p ET, Fox.

Continuity. Dropped as unchanged since Sept. 12: Nvidia-Hugging Face deal terms; Amazon FTC ad-auction suit; Ford/CATL battery scrutiny; Anthropic IPO timeline (still no S-1); Bab el-Mandeb/Red Sea Houthi control of Mokha and Perim Island. Corrected this issue: FedEx's earnings date (Oct. 28, not Sept. 18); the Fed chair is Kevin Warsh, not Powell — a standing fact, not a one-off. Watch for next issue: full corroboration of post-hike 2Y/30Y yield closes, DXY, and VIX against primary sources; whether Aramco's East-West pipeline restoration proceeds on the six-week timeline; whether any party invokes the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement over this week's pipeline strike; attribution of that strike (Iraq-origin drones vs. Houthi operation, unresolved); today's housing starts, industrial production, and weekly jobless claims once released; the Yankees' exact post-Wednesday record.

Unverified figures are marked in red. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.